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There is a particular kind of grief in sport that has little to do with defeat. It arrives not when a team loses, but when time finally catches up with the players who once seemed beyond its reach.

This World Cup has felt full of those moments. Neymar's international career came to an end in tears with Brazil's exit. Luka Modric departed with Croatia gone.

Cristiano Ronaldo, who for so long bent matches to his will, walked away from another World Cup. Manuel Neuer, for years football's last great illusionist in goal, no longer carried the same aura of permanence.

These were not merely elite footballers but part of the architecture of the modern game, figures so omnipresent for so long that they came to feel less like athletes and more like fixed points in our own lives.

Every major tournament had them somewhere in the frame. Neymar dancing through defenders with the swagger and invention that made him one of football's last great street footballers. Modric gliding through midfield with that strange combination of delicacy and defiance. Ronaldo summoning goals and drama by force of habit. Neuer redrawing what a sweeper-goalskeeper could be.

Their brilliance stretched across so many summers that it began to feel normal, and that was perhaps the greatest trick of all. Greatness, repeated often enough, starts to masquerade as permanence.

Painful farewell: Cristiano Ronaldo's final World Cup ended in heartbreak as Portugal fell 1-0 to Spain in the last 16, leaving one of football's greatest careers without the game's biggest prize. GETTY IMAGES